Module 6: Effective Communication and Stakeholder Management

Lead without authority — structure your thinking, write clear PRDs, align stakeholders, negotiate trade-offs and communicate with every function.

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MODULE 6

Effective Communication and Stakeholder Management

Lead without authority — structure your thinking, write clear PRDs, align stakeholders, negotiate trade-offs and communicate with every function.

≈ 9 h study

About the dialogues

Conversations in this module are **illustrative scripts** written to model technique. They are not transcripts of real meetings.

6.1 Why communication is the PM's core tool

PMs rarely have formal authority over the people who build, sell or support the product. Influence comes from **clarity, evidence, trust and consistency.** Most PM failures are communication failures: unclear problems, unshared trade-offs, surprises, or decisions nobody wrote down.

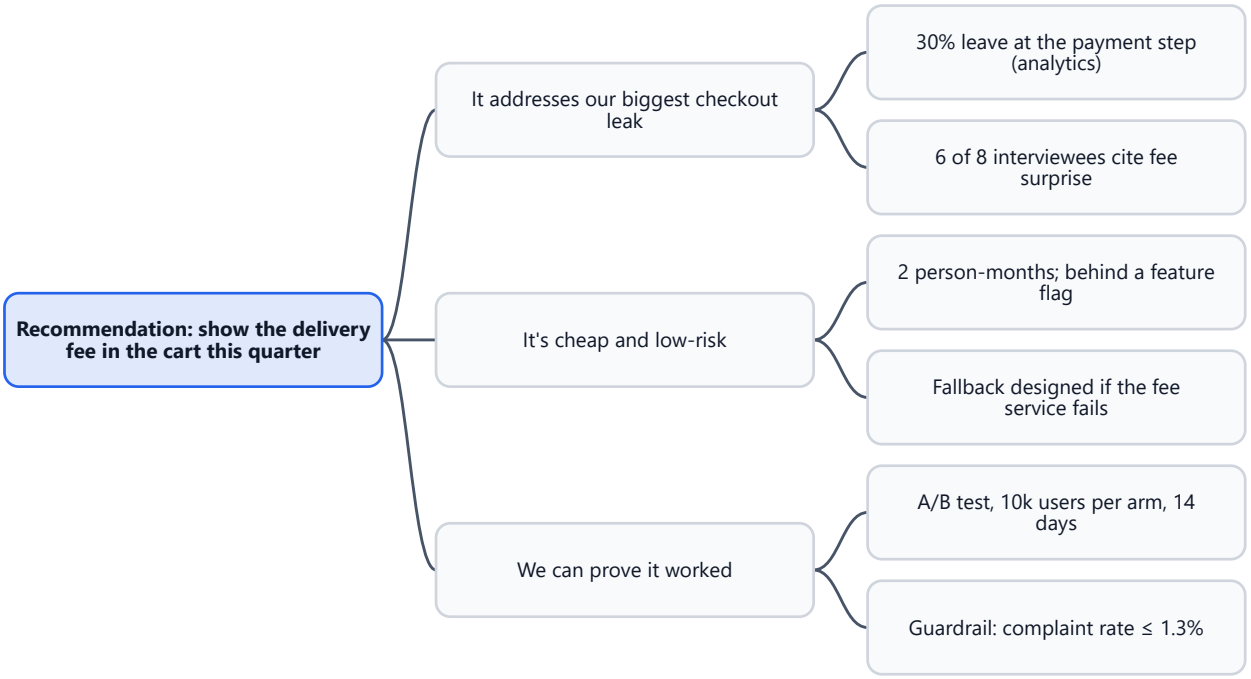
Principles

1. **Start with the answer** (then support it).
2. **Know your audience** — what decision do *they* need to make, and what do they care about?
3. **Make trade-offs explicit** — options, cost, benefit, risk.
4. **Separate facts, assumptions and opinions** — label each.
5. **Write it down** — decisions, owners, dates.
6. **No surprises** — share bad news early, with a plan.
7. **Listen more than you talk** — especially with customers and engineers.

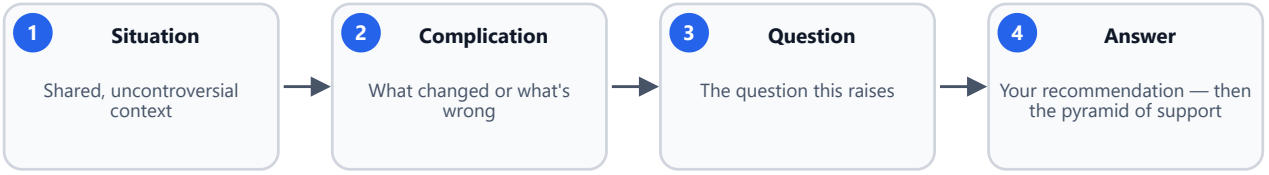
6.2 Structured problem-solving communication

6.2.1 The Pyramid Principle and SCQA

Barbara Minto's **Pyramid Principle**: lead with the governing thought (answer), group supporting arguments (ideally mutually exclusive and collectively exhaustive, **MECE**), and support each with evidence. **SCQA** frames the opening: **Situation → Complication → Question → Answer.**



Pyramid structure for a recommendation (hypothetical). The answer comes first; each branch is a reason; leaves are evidence. Executives can stop reading at any level and still have the point.



SCQA — how to open any update, memo or pitch. Executives should be able to stop after the Answer and still act. Everything after it is supporting evidence.

SCQA opening (hypothetical)

Situation: Checkout completion is 70% and is our largest growth lever this quarter. **Complication:** 30% of users leave at the payment step, and research says the fee surprises them. **Question:** What should we change first? **Answer:** Show the full fee breakdown in the cart, tested as an A/B experiment over two weeks.

6.2.2 Executive summaries

An executive summary fits on one screen: **the ask/decision, the recommendation, why (2–3 bullets with numbers), risks and mitigations, what you need (people, money, decision by date).** Put it at the top of every doc.

Executive summary template

Decision needed by 15 May: approve 2 engineers for 6 weeks to test early fee display. **Recommendation:** run an A/B test; ship only if checkout completion rises ≥ 2 points with no rise in complaints. **Why:** the payment step loses 30% of starters; 6/8 users cite fee surprise; est. +2,160 orders/month (range 720–4,320). **Risks:** fee estimate inaccuracy → label as estimate, fallback text; delay to loyalty work by 3 weeks. **Not doing:** loyalty redesign until Q3.

6.2.3 STAR and PREP

- **STAR** (behavioural answers): **Situation, Task, Action, Result** — with *your* actions and a real result (or say it wasn't measured).
- **PREP** (quick opinions and updates): **Point, Reason, Example, Point** — great for meetings and 60-second answers.

Situation	Structure	Shape	Typical length
Recommendation to leadership	Pyramid + SCQA	Answer → reasons → evidence	1 page / 3 minutes
Behavioural interview story	STAR	Situation → Task → Action → Result	2 minutes
Opinion in a meeting or stand-up	PREP	Point → Reason → Example → Point	30–60 seconds
Feedback to a colleague	SBI	Situation → Behaviour → Impact → ask	2 minutes
Bad news / incident	What · impact · cause · plan · next update	Facts first, then plan	5 sentences

Choosing a communication structure. Pick the structure by audience and purpose. All five put the most important information first.

Key points: STAR stories

Structure experience stories as Situation, Task, Action — what you personally did — and Result, backed by evidence where you have it. Tell it conversationally, and if you never measured the result, say so instead of inventing a figure.

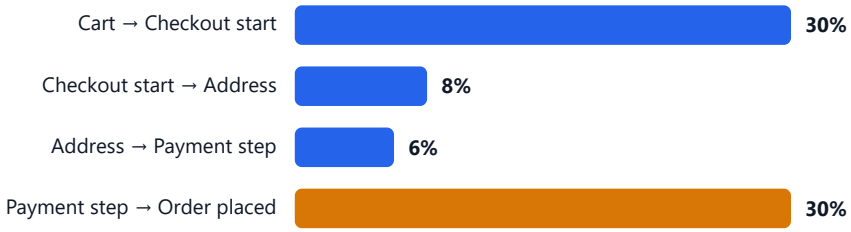
PREP in a stand-up (hypothetical)

Point: We should delay the loyalty launch by a week. **Reason:** payment errors spiked 3× after Tuesday's release. **Example:** 412 failed attempts yesterday vs ~130 normal. **Point:** let's fix payments first, then launch loyalty next Wednesday.

6.3 Storytelling with data

Data persuades when it answers a question for a specific audience. Principles (in the spirit of Cole Nussbaumer Knaflic's *Storytelling with Data*):

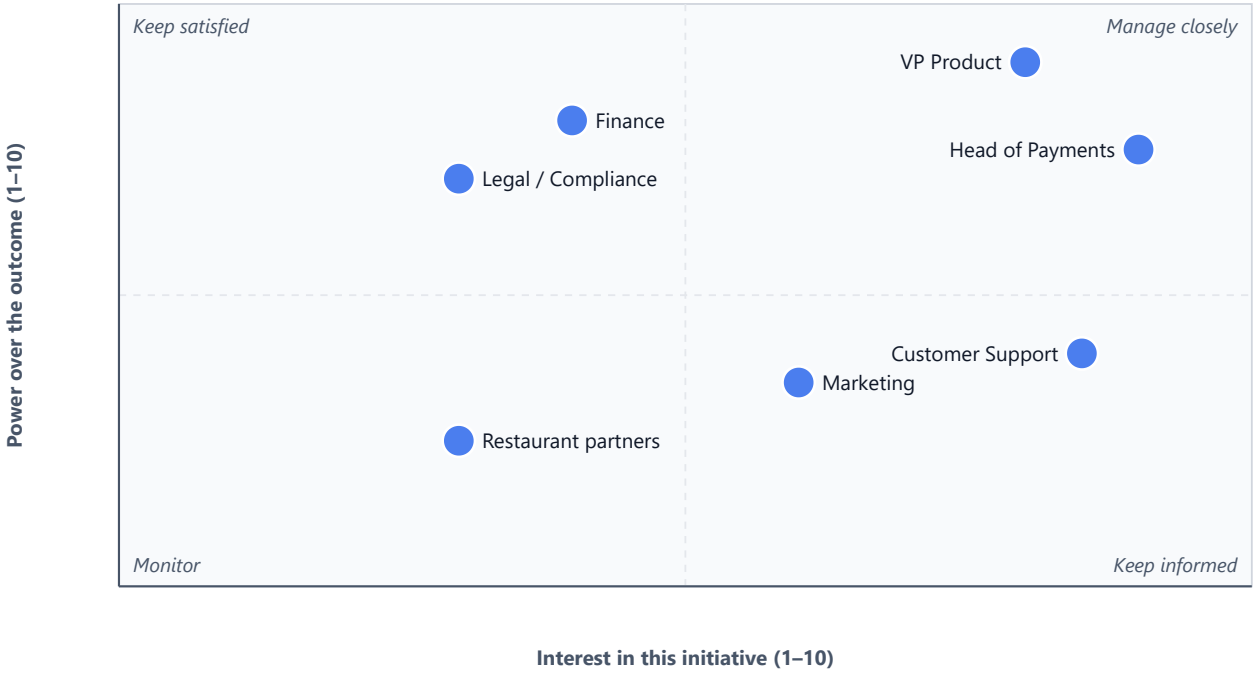
1. **Lead with the takeaway as the chart title** ("Checkout loses most users at payment"), not "Funnel Q1".
2. **Choose the right chart:** trend → line; comparison → bar; part-to-whole with few parts → stacked bar; distribution → histogram; relationship → scatter. Avoid 3D and pie charts with many slices.
3. **Remove clutter;** highlight the one thing that matters with colour.
4. **Give context:** baseline, target, comparison period, sample size.
5. **Show uncertainty** (ranges, confidence intervals).
6. **End with the action** you want.



Checkout loses the most users at the payment step (hypothetical). Drop-off at each step (% of users entering the step). The title states the takeaway; colour highlights the step the recommendation targets. Hypothetical data.

6.4 Stakeholder mapping and influence

Stakeholder mapping identifies who matters and how to engage them. The **power–interest grid**: *manage closely* (high power, high interest), *keep satisfied* (high power, low interest), *keep informed* (low power, high interest), *monitor* (low, low).



Power–interest grid for a checkout redesign (hypothetical). Hypothetical placement. Re-map as the project changes; a low-interest, high-power stakeholder (Legal) can block a launch late if ignored.

Decision-rights frameworks

- **RACI** — **R**esponsible (does the work), **A**ccountable (one person owns the outcome), **C**onsulted (two-way input), **I**nformed (kept updated).
- **DACI** — **D**river (runs the decision process), **A**pprover (one person decides), **C**ontributors, **I**nformed. Useful for product decisions.

Role	Who	What they do
Driver	PM, Checkout	Frames options, gathers evidence, schedules the decision
Approver	Head of Product	Makes the call by the agreed date
Contributors	Design, Eng lead, Analytics, Payments, Legal	Provide input, risks, estimates
Informed	Support, Marketing, Sales	Told the decision and its implications

DACI for "Ship early fee display?" (hypothetical). One approver per decision. Writing this down before the debate prevents most escalations.

Influence without authority — what actually works: shared goals ("we both want fewer failed payments"), evidence, reciprocity (help others hit *their* goals), early involvement ("co-authors defend what they wrote"), credibility through follow-through, and making it easy to say yes (clear asks, small first steps).

6.5 Cross-functional collaboration

Partner	What they need from you	What you need from them	Common friction
Engineering	Clear problem, priorities, early involvement, stable scope	Estimates, risks, technical options	Late requirement changes; dates set without them
Design	Problem, evidence, constraints, time to explore	Flows, prototypes, research partnership	Solution-first requests; skipping research
Data / Analytics	Questions, decisions, tracking needs early	Definitions, analysis, experiment design	Ad-hoc requests with no decision attached
Marketing / PMM	Positioning inputs, launch dates, user value	Messaging, launch plans, market feedback	Late notice; overpromising
Sales	Roadmap context, honest timelines	Customer feedback, deal blockers	Promising features to close deals
Support / Ops	Release notes, known issues, training	Ticket trends, customer pain	Launches without support readiness
Legal / Compliance	Early sight of data use and claims	Risk assessment, approvals	Brought in at the last minute

6.6 Negotiation and conflict resolution

Negotiation principles (from *Getting to Yes*, Fisher & Ury): separate the **people** from the problem; focus on **interests**, not positions; invent **options** for mutual gain; use **objective criteria**; know your **BATNA** (best alternative to a negotiated agreement).

Interests, not positions (hypothetical)

Position (Sales): "We need custom reports for Client X by June." **Interest:** keep a renewal worth ₹40 lakh; client's finance team needs monthly numbers. **Options:** scheduled CSV export (2 weeks), template report in existing tool (1 week), full custom reports (3 months). **Objective criteria:** revenue at risk, number of other clients asking, engineering cost. **Outcome:** ship the scheduled export now; evaluate custom reports in Q3 planning.

SALES POSITION

- "Build custom reports for Client X by June."

PRODUCT POSITION

- "Not this quarter — checkout comes first."

SALES INTEREST

- Keep a ₹40 lakh renewal
- Client's finance team needs monthly numbers

PRODUCT INTEREST

- Hit the checkout-completion goal
- Avoid one-off custom features

OPTIONS THAT SERVE BOTH

- Scheduled CSV export in 2 weeks (meets the client's job)
- Custom reports evaluated in Q3 with evidence from other clients

Positions versus interests (hypothetical Sales vs Product example). Positions collide; interests usually overlap. Find the options in the bottom row before arguing about the top row.

Conflict modes (Thomas–Kilmann): competing, collaborating, compromising, avoiding, accommodating.



Thomas–Kilmann conflict modes. Conceptual positions, not measurements. No mode is always right — match it to stakes, time and relationship.

PMs default to **collaborating** for important, high-trust issues; **compromising** for time-bound trade-offs; **accommodating** on low-stakes items to build goodwill; **avoid** only for trivia.

A conflict-resolution sequence: (1) restate each side's interest until they agree you understood; (2) agree on the shared goal and decision criteria; (3) lay out options with evidence; (4) decide — or escalate *together* with a joint summary; (5) document and move on.

6.7 Decision-making meetings

- **Before:** circulate a one-page decision brief 24–48 hours ahead (context, options, recommendation, evidence, open questions); state the decision type (decide, consult, inform).
- **During:** confirm the decision and decider; walk through options and trade-offs; invite dissent explicitly (“what would make this wrong?”); decide or agree what information is missing.
- **After:** within 24 hours send the decision, rationale, owner, next steps and review date.



Anatomy of a decision meeting. Most of the work happens before and after the meeting. If nobody read the pre-read, spend the first five minutes reading it together.

Key points: decision meetings

Send a one-page brief before the meeting. In the meeting, lay out the options, trade-offs and open questions. Afterwards, write down the decision, who owns it, why it was made and when it will be reviewed. Disagreement is valuable when it surfaces a risk nobody had seen.

6.8 Writing PRDs

A **PRD** aligns the team on the problem and intended solution. It is a living document, sized to the team's needs.

Key points: PRDs and AI drafting

A solid PRD names the objective, target users, goals, success metrics, requirements, design links, what is out of scope and the open questions. Pick metrics that fit the specific problem, mixing business, user and technical measures; example targets are not forecasts. An AI tool can produce a first draft, but check every assumption, number, privacy point and fact before sharing. Linking a Confluence page to Jira items and design files keeps work findable; version history shows what changed; page permissions should match the intended readers. When discussing estimates, ask engineers about complexity, testing, risks and dependencies without blame, then explain the trade-offs.

1 · SUMMARY & DECISION

- One paragraph: problem, proposal, expected impact
- Status, owner, reviewers, last updated

2 · PROBLEM & EVIDENCE

- Who, what task, why it's hard
- Data, research, quotes (with sample sizes)

3 · GOALS & SUCCESS METRICS

- Primary outcome metric and target
- Leading indicators; guardrails

4 · USERS & USE CASES

- Segments/personas
- Key scenarios and edge cases

5 · SCOPE

- In scope / out of scope
- Assumptions and dependencies

6 · REQUIREMENTS

- User stories + acceptance criteria
- Non-functional: performance, security, accessibility, privacy

7 · DESIGN & ANALYTICS

- Links to flows/prototypes
- Tracking plan (events, properties)

8 · LAUNCH & RISKS

- Rollout plan, flags, rollback
- Risks + mitigations; open questions; decision log

PRD skeleton. The full reusable template is in the Templates library. Keep the summary on top; link rather than duplicate detail.

Mini-PRD: Show estimated total before checkout (hypothetical)

Problem. First-time mobile buyers abandon at payment; 30% of checkout starters leave at that step; 6 of 8 interviewees said the fee surprised them. **Goal.** Checkout completion for first-time buyers 70% → 76% this quarter; guardrail: complaint rate ≤ 1.3%; payment-error rate unchanged. **In scope.** Item total + estimated delivery/platform fees and taxes in the cart; "est." labels; refresh on address change; fallback "Estimate unavailable" with retry. **Out of scope.** Changing the fee policy; personalised fees. **User story.** *As a first-time buyer, I want to see my estimated total in the cart so that I can decide before I start paying.* **Acceptance criteria (Gherkin).** *Given* an eligible address, *when* the user opens the cart, *then* show item price, estimated fees, taxes and estimated total. *Given* the fee service fails, *when* the cart loads, *then* show "Estimate unavailable" and a keyboard-accessible Retry, and never display an invented fee. *Given* the user changes the address, *when* the cart reloads, *then* the estimate refreshes within 2 seconds (p95). **Non-functional.** WCAG 2.2 AA; no PII in analytics events; works on 3G within 3 s (p95). **Analytics.** `fee_displayed` {fee_amount, is_estimate, source}; `fee_estimate_failed` {error_code}. **Rollout.** Feature flag; A/B 50/50; 14 days; kill switch owner: Eng lead. **Open questions.** Should the fee estimate include surge? Legal wording for "estimate"?



How a PRD connects to delivery tools. The PRD explains why and what; Jira tracks how and when. Link them both ways so a reader can trace any ticket back to the problem it solves.

6.8.1 User stories and acceptance criteria

- **User story:** *As a [user], I want [capability] so that [benefit].*
- **INVEST** checklist: Independent, Negotiable, Valuable, Estimable, Small, Testable.
- **Acceptance criteria:** testable conditions, often written **Given / When / Then.**
- **Definition of Ready** (criteria before work starts) vs **Definition of Done** (quality criteria for completed work).

6.8.2 Writing one-pagers

A **one-pager** pitches an idea before a full PRD: problem, why now, who, proposed approach, expected impact (with range), cost, risks, the ask. If you can't write it on one page, the idea isn't clear yet. (Amazon popularised the related **PR/FAQ** — a mock press release and FAQ written before building — as a way to test whether the customer benefit is compelling.)

6.8.3 Jira and Confluence in the workflow

Key points: Jira and Confluence

Jira tracks work items, workflows and delivery: projects hold the work, boards show status, and teams use stories, tasks, bugs and epics in their own way. Sprints belong to Scrum; not every team uses them. Practice: create an item such as “Show estimated total before checkout” with the user, outcome, scope and acceptance criteria, then move it through your team's workflow. Look for blocked and ageing items and discuss causes; story points are not a measure of individual productivity. Confluence organises pages into spaces for PRDs, decision logs, research and launch checklists; link the related Jira items, record scope changes with dates, and check who can see each page.

6.9 Engineering collaboration

- **Involve engineers in discovery** — they often see the simplest solution.
- **Ask for estimates as ranges with assumptions,** not commitments on the spot.
- **Story points** are relative effort for a team's planning — not a productivity score and not comparable across teams.
- **Trade scope, not quality:** offer smaller slices before asking for overtime.
- **Respect technical debt** — reserve capacity; understand the cost of delay of not fixing it.
- **Be available** during the sprint to answer questions quickly.

Dialogue — negotiating scope with an engineering lead (illustrative)

PM: “Our goal is to stop the fee surprise for first-time buyers this quarter. What's the simplest version you'd build?” **Eng lead:** “Showing a static fee is easy. A live estimate needs the pricing service — three weeks, and it's flaky at peak.” **PM:** “What if v1 shows the estimate when the service responds within 500 ms and otherwise ‘Estimate unavailable’? Would that cut the time?” **Eng lead:** “Then it's about ten days. We'd add a cache later.” **PM:** “Great. Let's take that, put it behind a flag and A/B it. I'll update the PRD and note the cache as a follow-up. Anything else risky?” **Eng lead:** “Analytics events — let's define them now so QA can check them.” *Why it works:* goal first, asks for the simplest option, trades scope not quality, records the follow-up.

6.10 Communicating with every function — dialogue examples

With senior leadership (illustrative)

VP: "Why isn't loyalty on the Q2 roadmap?" **PM:** "Short answer: checkout completion is a bigger, faster lever. We lose 30% of buyers at payment; fixing that is worth an estimated 2,000+ orders a month, and it takes 6 weeks. Loyalty only helps people who complete checkout. I'd like your approval to run the checkout test first, and I'll bring a loyalty proposal to the Q3 review with the test results." *Technique:* answer first, number, trade-off, specific ask, follow-up date.

With design (illustrative)

PM: "Six of eight users missed the fee. I'm not attached to any layout — what are the options you see?" **Designer:** "A breakdown in the cart, or a sticky total bar." **PM:** "Can we test both with five users next week and decide using task success?"

With analytics (illustrative)

PM: "The decision is whether to ship early fee display. I need: completion per eligible user by variant, complaint rate, and a power estimate for detecting +2 points." **Analyst:** "At 70% baseline that's about 8,000 users per arm." **PM:** "Then we run 14 days. Can we pre-register the metric definitions in the doc?"

With operations / support (illustrative)

PM: "From Monday, 50% of users will see an estimated fee in the cart. Here's the help article and three macros. If customers say 'the fee changed', tag it `fee_estimate` — I'll review tags daily during the test."

With a customer (illustrative)

Customer: "Your app always surprises me with fees." **PM:** "I'm sorry — that's exactly what we're trying to fix. Could you walk me through the last time it happened? What did you expect to see?" *(Listen; don't defend; don't promise dates.)* "Thank you. We're testing a change that shows the full estimate earlier; may I follow up to get your feedback?"

6.11 Handling conflicting priorities and difficult stakeholders

Conflicting priorities: bring them to a common yardstick (the goal and a framework such as RICE or cost of delay), make trade-offs visible, escalate *jointly* if needed with a one-page options paper, and record the decision.

Difficult stakeholders — patterns and responses

Pattern	Response
The HiPPO (highest-paid person's opinion)	Ask for the goal behind the idea; propose a test; show data respectfully
The bulldozer (“just build it”)	Acknowledge urgency; show cost of delay of displaced work; offer a smaller slice
The silent blocker	1:1 conversation; ask what would make them comfortable; involve early
The scope-creeper	Refer to the agreed scope and decision log; queue new asks for the next cycle
The customer-promiser (sales)	Shared rule: no commitments without PM sign-off; give roadmap themes, not dates

> **Key points: competing incentives**
>
> Sales may push for one customer's request, engineering for reliability work, users for speed. Rather than promising everything, agree on the shared outcome, the evidence, the constraints and who has the final say.

6.12 Customer empathy

Empathy is *understanding the customer's situation and feelings well enough to make better decisions* — not agreeing with every request. Practise it through regular customer calls, listening to support calls, reading tickets, using the product as a new user, and shadowing operations.

6.13 Giving and receiving feedback

SBI model: Situation (when/where), **Behaviour** (observable, not judgement), **Impact** (effect on you, team, user). Then ask, listen and agree next steps.

> **SBI (illustrative)**
>
> "In yesterday's review (S), the PRD's success metric changed from completion to clicks without a note (B). Engineering built tracking for the old metric and lost a day (I). Could we add a change log to the PRD so everyone sees updates?"

Receiving feedback: thank, clarify, don't defend in the moment, decide what to act on, close the loop.

Audience	Format	Cadence	Contents
Leadership	One-page update	Weekly / fortnightly	Metrics vs target, decisions needed, risks
Cross-functional partners	Channel post + sync	Weekly	Progress, blockers, upcoming asks
Support & sales	Release notes + FAQ	Per release	What changed, how to explain it, known issues
Whole company	Demo / newsletter	Monthly	Outcomes and learnings
Anyone affected by an incident	Incident message	Immediately, then on a schedule	Impact, plan, next update time

Tiered stakeholder communication cadence (example). Match depth and frequency to each audience's decisions. No surprises — risks go out early, through the channel the audience actually reads.

6.14 Leadership communication and executive product reviews

Executives want: **the decision you need, how it serves the strategy, the numbers, the risks, and what you're not doing.** Prepare for an exec review:

1. **One-page memo** at the top (or a 6-page narrative memo in memo-culture companies).
2. **Metrics vs targets** with honest status (green/amber/red with reasons).
3. **Learnings** — what surprised you, what you stopped.
4. **Decisions needed** — clearly listed.
5. **Appendix** for detail; anticipate the three hardest questions.

Delivering bad news: state it plainly, the impact, the cause (if known), what you're doing, what you need, when you'll update next.

6.15 Exercises with model answers

Exercise 1 · Rewrite an update with the Pyramid Principle

Original: "We did lots of analysis this week. We looked at funnels, did interviews, talked to payments, and engineering thinks it's 2 months. Fees might be a problem. Also loyalty is pending."

Model answer

"**Recommendation:** test showing the delivery fee in the cart, starting next sprint. **Why:** (1) 30% of checkout starters leave at payment; (2) 6 of 8 interviewees cite fee surprise; (3) engineering estimates a simplified v1 at ~2 weeks (full live estimate ~2 months). **Ask:** approve the two-week v1 and an A/B test; loyalty moves to Q3."

Exercise 2 · Acceptance criteria

Write three Given/When/Then criteria for "saved addresses".

Model answer

Given a logged-in user with no saved addresses, *when* they complete an order with a new address, *then* offer "Save this address" (unchecked by default). *Given* a user with saved addresses, *when* they open checkout, *then* show up to 5 most recent addresses with the last used pre-selected. *Given* a saved address fails validation, *when* it is selected, *then* show a plain-language error and an Edit option without losing the cart.

Exercise 3 · Stakeholder map

For launching a fintech card-application redesign, place six stakeholders on a power–interest grid and give one engagement action each.

Model answer (example)

Manage closely: Head of Risk (co-design KYC changes), Compliance (review copy and consent). Keep satisfied: CFO (monthly KPI summary). Keep informed: Customer Support (training and macros), Marketing (launch messaging). Monitor: partner bank's ops team (notify of timeline). Re-map after the pilot.

6.16 Interview perspective

"Tell me about a time you influenced without authority." — STAR model answer outline

S: Team wanted to build a feature a large client requested; I believed checkout reliability was more urgent. **T:** Align sales, engineering and my VP on priorities. **A:** Pulled funnel data and support tags, quantified lost orders, met sales to understand the client's real need, proposed a 2-week workaround for the client, and presented options with a recommendation. **R:** We fixed payment retries first; failed-payment recoveries rose (state the real measured number — or say it wasn't measured); the client accepted the workaround and renewed. **Learning:** start with shared goals and offer options. *Mistake to avoid:* inventing results or describing only what the team did.

"How would you communicate a delayed launch to executives?" — 60-second answer

"I'd tell them as soon as I know, in one message: the launch will slip by two weeks; the cause is a payment-gateway certification we underestimated; the impact is roughly X orders and no customer-facing risk; options are to launch without the new payment method or wait; my recommendation is to wait because the old flow is the main pain point; and I'll update them every Friday until launch. Then I'd document the learning for future estimates."

6.17 Key takeaways

- **Answer first** (Pyramid/SCQA); support with MECE reasons and evidence.
- Use **STAR** for stories and **PREP** for quick points; never invent outcomes.
- Make **decision rights** explicit (RACI/DACI) and write decisions down.
- Negotiate on **interests**, with options and objective criteria.
- PRDs are **living alignment tools**: problem, metrics, scope, testable requirements, risks.
- Tailor to each function's needs; **no surprises.**

6.18 Check your understanding

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

The Pyramid Principle recommends...

A. Building up to the conclusion at the end

B. Starting with the answer, then grouped supporting arguments

C. Listing all data first

D. Using only charts

Why: Lead with the governing thought, then MECE support and evidence.

In DACI, who makes the final decision?

A. Driver

B. Approver

C. Contributors

D. Informed

Why: The Approver decides; the Driver runs the process.

Which is a well-formed acceptance criterion?

A. The page should be fast.

B. Given an eligible address, when the cart opens, then show the estimated total.

C. Make the cart better.

D. Users will like it.

Why: Acceptance criteria are specific and testable, often Given/When/Then.

Focusing on interests rather than positions means...

A. Agreeing to every request

B. Understanding the need behind a demand to find better options

C. Refusing to negotiate

D. Escalating immediately

Why: Interests reveal options that satisfy the underlying need.

Story points are best described as...

A. A measure of individual productivity

B. Relative effort estimates for a team's planning

C. Hours of work

D. Comparable across all teams

Why: Story points are team-relative planning estimates, not productivity scores.

6.19 Recommended resources

- Barbara Minto, *The Pyramid Principle* — publisher page.
- Cole Nussbaumer Knaflic, *Storytelling with Data*.
- Fisher, Ury & Patton, *Getting to Yes* — Harvard Program on Negotiation.
- Atlassian: DACI decision-making framework.
- Atlassian Support: Create a Jira work item and Use Jira and Confluence together.
- Center for Creative Leadership: SBI feedback model.